

3.2 Printing Your Digital Photos

If you've been wondering why, even after buying yourself a great photo printer and using the best quality paper, you can't seem to match the quality of prints you get from photo stores, chances are you haven't really been optimising the picture for the perfect print. Sure there's a variety of software out there that offers to print for you, but if you don't mind spending a little extra time, then here are a few suggestions that can make your prints stand out from the crowd.

Print Size (inches)	Good Results (200 dpi)	Best Results (300 dpi)
4 x 6	800 by 1200 pixels (about 1 megapixel)	1200 by 1800 pixels (about 2 megapixels)
5 x 7	1000 by 1400 pixels (about 1.5 megapixels)	1500 by 2100 pixels (about 3 megapixels)
8 x 10	1600 by 2000 pixels (about 3 megapixels)	2400 by 3000 pixels (about 7 megapixels)
11 x 14	2200 by 2800 pixels (about 6 megapixels)	3300 by 4200 pixels (about 14 megapixels)
16 x 20	3200 by 4000 pixels (about 13 megapixels)	4800 by 6000 pixels (about 29 megapixels)

First, if you're taking pictures for the purpose of printing, always shoot them at the maximum resolution your camera has to offer. For a better idea, just follow the table below to check how big your picture needs to be in order to fit it to a particular print size.

That said, it's not a good idea to print a large image on a comparatively smaller-sized paper. It can be done, but the results may not look as good as it would if you take a little time to resize the image to fit the print size. The reason for this is that most inkjet printers are not capable of scaling down images efficiently. You may find jagged edges, artefacts and other such errors if you try printing an enormous image on a smaller paper. For a guide on resizing images and optimising them for print, refer to Section 2.2.

Some Tips To Perfect Your Print Quality

- Premium glossy photo paper gives the best results when printing photos. The gloss tends to bring out better colours overall.